

MADE TO STICK

Why Some Ideas Survive and Others Die

Chip & Dan Heath

The Big “So What”



Based on 10 years of study, the book answers the question “why do some ideas succeed while others die”, and provides a practical and systematic way to create ideas that are understood, remembered, and have a long-term impact.

Introduction

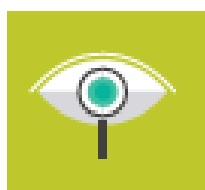


A sticky idea is one that is understandable, memorable, and actually changes perspectives or behaviours. Not all ideas are “stick-worthy”, though it is possible to systematically create sticky ideas, or to learn to spot ideas with potential. After studying a wide range of ideas and how they are communicated, the Heath Brothers identified 6 principles (SUCCEsSs) that can be applied as a template or checklist to shape or test any idea for stickiness. The book also addresses barriers to application and how to overcome them with the SUCCEsSs principles:

- | | |
|------------|--|
| Simple | : Find the core of our ideas |
| Unexpected | : Get audience’s attention, sustain their interest |
| Concrete | : Make the message clear |
| Credible | : Make people believe our ideas |
| Emotional | : Make people care |
| Stories | : Get people to act |

1

Simplicity: Finding the Core



Simplicity is not just about using fewer words, shorter phrases or sound bites. It is about:

- Finding the essential core of our ideas; and
- Sharing it in a form of a compact idea

KEY QUOTES

“We wrote this book to help you make your ideas stick. By “stick” we mean that your ideas are understood and remembered, and have a lasting impact – they change your audience’s opinions or behaviours.”

“As we pored over hundreds of sticky ideas, we saw, over and over, the same six principles at work”

“The SUCCEsSs checklist is intended to be a deeply practical tool...It requires diligence and it requires awareness.”

Simplicity

“To strip an idea down to its core, we must be masters of exclusion. We must relentless prioritize.”

Simple = CORE + COMPACT

For an idea to be compact, there must be **a lot of meaning packed into a succinct message**, i.e. "a one-sentence statement so profound that an individual could spend a life-time learning to follow it", thereby making an enduring impact, e.g. the proverb "Do unto others as you would have them do unto you."



To create compact communications:

- **Use flags to tap into existing schemas of your audience**
Schemas are a collection of properties related to a concept, category or object. When we help our audience to tap into their memory terrain or schema of an object (e.g. the colour, size, taste associated with a "grapefruit"), we can teach them an idea without listing all the attributes ourselves.
- **Create a high-concept pitch to summarize your vision in 1 line**
Use analogies that your target audience understand to call up schemas then adapt it, e.g. "Its Jaws in space!" (Alien) or "We network networks." (Cisco).
- **Use generative analogy that enrich your ideas**
Generative analogies not only brings understanding to a new concept, they become platforms for new ideas, perspectives, and creations, e.g. Disney using the concept of cast members to describe their employees.

In sharing your core, **be careful not to bury the lead**, i.e. don't start with something irrelevant but interesting. Instead, **focus on making the core message more interesting**.



2 Unexpectedness: Getting the Audience's Attention and Sustained Interest



There are 2 parts to this principle:

- **Get Attention** through the emotion of **Surprise**
- **Keep Attention** through the emotion of **Interest**

Getting attention

Humans adapt quickly and tune out to consistent patterns. Our brains are however alert to changes. Hence, **the best way to get someone's attention is to break a pattern**.

KEY QUOTES

"The Golden Rule : a one-sentence statement so profound that an individual could spend a lifetime learning to follow it".

"Compact ideas alone aren't valuable - only ideas with profound compactness are valuable. So, to make a profound idea compact, you've got to pack a lot of meaning into a little bit of messaging."

"People are tempted to tell you everything, with perfect accuracy, right up front, when they should be giving you just enough info to be useful, then a little more, then a little more".

Unexpectedness

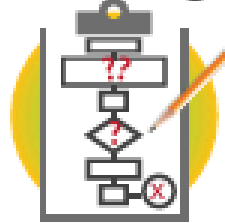
"Unexpectedness, in the service of core principles, can have surprising longevity."

We use our schemas to constantly guess and predict what will happen next and to make decisions. When our “guessing machines” fail, we are surprised, alert and focused on finding the answer to resolve why we are surprised. **This is how you can create surprise:**

- Identify the **key message** (the core) you wish to communicate
- **Identify what is counterintuitive** about the message, or what are the unexpected implications from this message
- Communicate your message in a way that **breaks your audience's guessing machines, then help them to refine their machines.**

When going for big surprises, **be careful to avoid gimmickry. Make sure you help the audience to “fix” their machine at the end by connecting** the surprise back to your core message.

Sustaining interest



To create sustained interest, we need to engage people's curiosity, over time, by **systematically opening and filling their knowledge gaps. To generate ongoing curiosity:**

- **Create a mystery:** Mysteries come from an unexpected journey (not a momentary surprise) – we want to solve the mystery but are not sure how exactly to do that. Progressively give people information so they start to focus on what they don't know. Give people enough context of the issue so they'd start to care.
- **Use the gap theory.** Before we tell people the facts, they must realize they need those facts, i.e. we must open gaps before we close them. To help overconfident people (who think they know everything) to recognize a knowledge gap, help them realize that others disagree with them. When creating knowledge gaps, ensure they are not so big that they seem insurmountable.
- **Use the news-teaser approach:** Ask “what questions do I want my audience to ask?” instead of “what information do I want to convey?” Tease the audience to ask the right question.



3 Concreteness: Making our Ideas Clear

Experts tend to get more abstract because they have so much knowledge, they tend to see the patterns and insights

KEY QUOTES

“The best way to get people's attention is to break their existing schemas directly.”

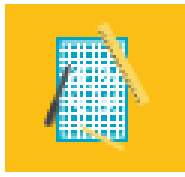
“If you want your ideas to be stickier, you've got to break someone's guessing machine and then fix it.”

“Unexpected ideas, by opening a knowledge gap, tease and flirt. They mark a big red X on something that needs to be discovered by does not necessarily tell you how to get there.”

“Use the gap theory of curiosity to our advantage. A little bit of mystery goes a long way.”

Concreteness

“Naturally sticky ideas are full of concrete images – icefilled bathtubs, apples with razors – because our brains are wired to remember concrete data... Speaking concretely is the only way to ensure that our idea will mean the same thing to everyone in our audience”.



between details, rather than the concrete details per se. **Abstract ideas are hard to understand and remember, and are open to different interpretation.**

- To **help people understand and remember**, we must make our ideas clear and concrete. Give a concrete context and build on what our audience already know and can identify with. **An idea is concrete when it brings up sensory information (feelings, smells, sounds etc.)**



Our memory works like Velcro with thousands of tiny loops and hooks: build more hooks into the idea to help it stick better in our memory.

- To **help people to coordinate better**, we should create a **“universal language” that everyone can speak fluently**. When people have the same sensory interpretation of the idea or challenge, it creates a “shared turf” that they can feel comfortable working in together.



Credibility: Making People Believe our Ideas



People generally believe ideas under the influence of family, personal experiences, faith, or authorities. However we can also build credibility into our ideas.

External Sources of Credibility

Use authorities and anti-authorities as a great source of credibility – we believe them if they seem honest and trustworthy, with no vested interest to promote the message



Internal Sources of Credibility

Use these tips to build credibility inside the message itself:

- Use convincing details:** When an idea comes with **vivid details that are truthful, relevant to our audience and support our core idea**, it makes the idea more tangible, real, and more believable.
- Use statistics effectively:** Use statistics as inputs to make up your mind on an issue, then **share these pivotal statistics to help the audience understand the underlying relationship**. Don't make up your mind and look for statistics as outputs to support the claim.

KEY QUOTES

“Trying to teach an abstract principle without concrete foundations is like trying to start a house by building a roof in the air.”

“The barrier is simply forgetfulness – we forget that we’re slipping into abstractspeak. We forget that other people don’t know what we know.”

Credibility

“If we’re trying to persuade a skeptical audience to believe a new message, the reality is that we’re fighting an uphill battle against a lifetime of personal learning and social relationships.”

“It can be the honesty and trustworthiness of our sources, not their status, that allows them to act as authorities.”

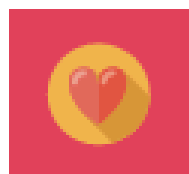
“We need to identify details that are compelling, human, meaningful – details that symbolize and support our core idea.”

Apply the human-scale principle when presenting statistics: Use scenarios which people can easily simulate in their minds (e.g. throwing a ball across a football field). This provides scale and context to make the idea more credible.

- **The Sinatra Test:** If one example or testimonial alone can establish credibility in a specific domain, this example passes the Sinatra Test
- **Provide a “testable credential”:** Let customers test a claim or idea for themselves, or “test before they buy”



Emotions: Getting People to Care about our Idea



For people to take action, they first have to care. Generally:

- **People tend to feel more for one individual than the masses.** When a problem seems so big, people care less as they feel that their own contributions are meaningless.
- **People feel less when they are presented with statistics,** which shift them into an analytical frame of mind.



To make people care:

- **Use associations:** Form an association between something that people care about and something they don't yet care about (your idea). However, when everyone is tapping on the same things that people care about, avoid this turf and find new, unique associations.
- **Appeal to self-interest:** Directly address “what is in it for me” for your audience. The magnitude of the benefits is not always as important as the tangibility of the benefits – It may be adequate to demonstrate modest benefits that people can clearly imagine themselves enjoying.
- **Appeal to identity:** Besides addressing the lower levels of Maslow's hierarchy of needs (self-interest), appeal to the audience's identity and aspirational needs, including their personal and group identities, and who they aspire to become. Ask “why” to remind people of the core values and principles that underlie our ideas.

KEY QUOTES

“Statistics will, and should, almost always be used to illustrate a relationship. It's more important for people to remember the relationships than the number.”

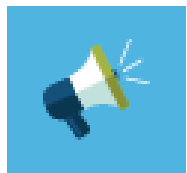
Emotions

“If I look at the mass, I will never act. If I look at the one, I will.”
- Mother Teresa

“How can we make people care about our ideas? We get them to take off their Analytical Hats. We create empathy for specific individuals. We show how our ideas are associated with things that people already care about. We appeal to their self-interest, but we also appeal to their identities – not only to the people they are right now, but also to the people they would like to be.”

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Stories: Getting People to Act on our Ideas



Stories can be powerful in providing:

- **Simulation** (knowledge on how to act); and
- **Inspiration** (motivation to take action)

Simulation: Know how to act

Mentally rehearsing a scenario helps us to perform better in actual situations, because it evokes the same parts of the brain that are used in physical activity. **Mental simulation provides as much as 2/3 of the benefits of actual physical practice**, and can help us manage emotions, solve problems, and build skills.



When we listen to stories, we tend to simulate it in our heads. **By creating stories in rich, comprehensive and life-like scenarios, we help our audience to simulate the idea mentally.** This allows them to experience and rehearse the idea from the inside, preparing them to act. According to the Velcro concept, the more hooks we have in our stories, the better they will stick

Motivation : Energy to act

After studying many stories, the Heath brothers identified **3 key plots that motivate action**:



The challenging plot: These stories are **about overcoming challenges**, e.g. include David vs Goliath stories, underdog stories, rags-to-riches stories, winning against the odds etc. They appeal to our sense of persistence, courage, and **inspire us to work harder, face challenges and conquer obstacles.**



The connection plot: These stories are **about relationships among people**, e.g. love stories, or people who bridge gaps in religion, class, class, religion etc. They **inspire us to be more altruistic, more loving, more tolerant, more collaborative etc.**



The creativity plot: These stories are **about mental breakthroughs, innovative solutions, or cracking a tough puzzle.** They inspire us to think differently, be more creative, and be more adventurous.

KEY QUOTES

Stories

"Stories have the amazing dual power to simulate and to inspire."

"Stories are like flight simulators for the brain."

Springboard stories (with visible goals and barriers) can be used to help people see possibilities. **By shifting the audience into a problem-solving mode, we help them to solve the problems for themselves.**

Using what Sticks



To get the message across effectively, the SUCCEs principles help you to achieve a few objectives, in 2 stages.

1) The Answer Stage

- Arrive at the idea you want to share → Simplicity

2) The Telling Others Stage

For an idea to stick, it must make the audience:

- Pay attention → Unexpectedness
- Understand and remember it → Concreteness
- Agree / believe → Credibility
- Care → Emotions
- Be able to act on it → Stories

Making Strategy Stick

Strategy should guide behaviour and drive actions that are aligned with the company's goals, delivers competitive advantage and financial success. Unfortunately, most strategies are academic, and do not drive action. There are several barriers to be overcome:



Barrier 1: The Curse of Knowledge

Executives tend to talk about strategy in abstract. A good way to overcome it is to **tell stories that are vivid, concrete, and bring to life the company's competitive advantage in day-to-day, on-the-ground terms. Tell the stories in 2 parts - the story itself, and the moral of the story.**



Barrier 2: Decision Paralysis

Decision paralysis can set in where there's too much choice (e.g. choosing between innovation vs efficiency) or ambiguity in the situation. Many strategies are not concrete enough for the typical employee to overcome decision paralysis. The solution is to **find the core, and translate that into priorities for day-to-day application.**

KEY QUOTES

"A strategy is, at its core, a guide to behaviour...A good strategy drives actions that differentiate the company and produce financial success."

"Sadly, there is a villain in our story. The villain is a natural psychological tendency that consistently confounds our ability to create ideas using these principles. Its called the Curse of knowledge".

"The strategy motto is a one-liner that brings clarity to an environment muddled with choices"



Barrier 3: Lack of a Common Language

Often, strategy is shared in an abstract way that employees find hard to communicate back to the leaders. When the strategy is clearly understood by everyone in the company, in the same way, then people can disagree or contribute constructively. **To avoid having an inert strategy, build it into the way your organization talks** – that way, it cannot be inert, and will in fact help to guide behaviour.

3 principles to making strategy stick:

1. Be concrete
2. Say something unexpected
3. Tell stories

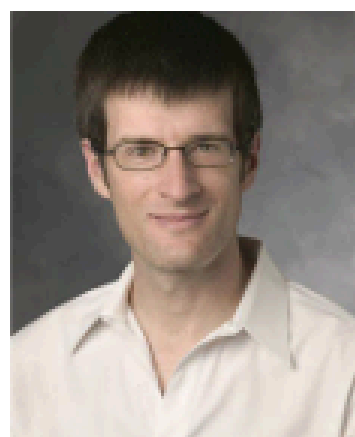
Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For



The Heath brothers identified the SUCCEsS principles after studying hundreds of case studies. Throughout the book, they share real-life, day-to-day examples that most of us can relate to e.g. urban legends, movies, proverbs and fables, airline flight safety announcements, education, department stores, etc.

They also outline numerous pivotal experiments that demonstrate how humans think and behave. The book also includes Idea Clinics that zoom into specific examples for the reader to model the process of making ideas stickier.

About the Author



Chip Heath is a professor at Stanford Graduate School of Business, focusing on courses about business strategy and organizations. He has consulted with clients such as Google, Gap and The Nature Conservancy.

Dan Heath is a Senior Fellow at Duke University's CASE center, which supports social entrepreneurs.

KEY QUOTES

"A common strategic language allows everyone to contribute."

"This book is filled with normal people facing normal problems who did amazing things simply by applying these principles (even if they weren't aware that they were doing it)"